

Understanding command words

Command words tell you how to answer a specific exam question or complete an assessment task. Below is a list of command words you will see in exam and assessment materials.

The definitions will help you understand what the words are asking you to do. The list does not include simple instruction words like **write**, **circle** or **find**.

Analyse	examine in detail to show meaning, and identify elements and the relationship between them
Assess	make an informed judgement
Calculate	work out from given facts, figures or information
Comment	give an informed opinion
Compare	identify/comment on similarities and/or differences
Consider	review and respond to given information
Contrast	identify/comment on differences
Define	give a precise meaning
Describe	state the points of a topic / give characteristics and main features
Develop	take forward to a more advanced stage or build upon given information
Discuss	write about issue(s) or topic(s) in depth in a structured way
Evaluate	judge or calculate the quality, importance, amount or value of something
Explain	set out purposes or reasons / make the relationships between things clear / say why and/or how and support with relevant evidence

Give	produce an answer from a given source or recall/memory
Identify	name/select/recognise
Justify	support a case with evidence/argument
Outline	set out the main points
Predict	suggest what may happen based on available information
Sketch	make a simple freehand drawing showing the key features, taking care over proportions
State	express in clear terms
Suggest	apply knowledge and understanding to situations where there are a range of valid responses to make proposals/put forward considerations
Summarise	choose and present the main points, without detail